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THE HIDDEN ULSTER

GAELIC PIONEERS OF THE NORTH

SEAMUS Ó NEILL

TOWARDS the end of the eighteenth century the North of Ireland, and particularly the North East, was the scene of considerable political excitement. Inspired by the American War of Independence, in which many of their relatives took part, the Dissenters, who suffered from certain religious and social disabilities, began to look for parliamentary reform in the hope of bettering their lot. Then came the French Revolution, and it was little wonder that its rallying call to the oppressed found ready ear in Ulster. The fall of the Bastile was celebrated in Belfast in July 1791, and on the 14 October of the same year the first society of United Irishmen was founded in that town. As Wolfe Tone expressed it, Tom Paine's *Rights of Man* had become the 'Koran of Blefescu'.

This is well known to the general reader of history, but what is not so well known is that at the same time there was a cultural awakening in the North, which like the cultural movement in our own time, was intertwined with the political movement. The descendants of the planters were beginning to adopt Irish nationality. This development was due to more than one factor. In their demand for equitable representation in Parliament, the Dissenters were logical enough to support the relaxation of the Penal Laws against the Catholics. The industrial revolution was already taking place in the Lagan valley. Cotton spinning had been introduced in 1777, the population of Belfast rose between the years 1779 and 1791 from 8,000 to 18,000; a new middle class was growing up, which was keen on education and learning. Lack of facilities for higher and even primary education was one of the grievances of the Dissenters. That great Presbyterian spokesman, and opponent of O'Connell, the Reverend Henry Cooke, for example, received his early education at a Catholic hedge school, and incidentally paid generous tribute to the classical scholarship of his poor Catholic teacher there, Frank Glass. The influence of MacPherson's *Ossian* was felt in Ireland as elsewhere; Charlotte Brooke published her *Reliques of Irish Poetry* in 1789, and from that date may be traced the beginnings of the Irish revival. As a result of all this, a harpers' festival was held in Belfast in July 1792 which was to leave its mark on the cultural history of Ireland down to this very day, and perhaps I should add on the political history.

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It is significant that the badge of the United Irishmen was a harp, with the legend 'It is re-strung and shall be heard'.

HARPERS' FESTIVAL

This harpers' festival was organized by Dr James McDonnell of the Glens of Antrim, Robert Simms, Henry Joy (Junior) and others. Robert Simms was the first secretary of the United Irishmen. Henry Joy was a cousin of Henry Joy McCracken. When Edward Bunting, the young organist of the Armagh Cathedral, was summoned to Belfast to write down the airs the harpers would play, he lodged with the McCrackens. Wolfe Tone was again in Belfast on a political mission during the festival, and looked in at it several times, although he was none too fond of the harp, and was convinced in his ignorance that all the good Irish airs had been already collected. He was, however, musical enough to name the best performer, Charles Fanning, who carried off the first prize of ten guineas with his rendering of *An Chúilfhionn*. Dr James McDonnell had no connection with the United Irishmen, but the affinity between the political and cultural nationalism of the day is clear. *The Northern Star,* the united organ, published one number of a Gaelic magazine called *Bolg an tSolair.*

The revolutionary spirit of the Dissenters vanished after '98, but an interest in Irish culture survived among many of the Northern Protestants. Appreciation of Irish airs led to an appreciation of Irish songs, and Irish songs led to the language. The organizers of the harpers' festival decided to continue their work. They employed Patrick Lynch, a well-known Irish scholar from Loughinisland in County Down to collect songs in the West. Lynch was followed by Bunting himself. Thus, these Belfast men anticipated by over a century the activities of the Irish Folklore Commission.

Drs James McDonnell, Samuel Neilson, Robert Bryson, James McKnight, the Reverend Henry Montgomery, and Robert McAdam were perhaps, the most distinguished of those Protestant Ulstermen who cultivated the Irish language and literature during the last century. Sir Samuel Ferguson and his friend George Fox studied the language in Belfast, as Ferguson himself tells us, and last but not least Jemmy Hope also read Irish. At the battle of Antrim a man named Hervey struck up the Marseillaise, but Jemmy Hope began a lively Irish air, which was soon taken up by the whole army.

THOMAS RUSSELL

The Belfast Society for Promoting Knowledge, which had been founded

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as the Belfast Reading Society in 1788, early took an interest in the language. The Honourable Charles Lynd presented the Society with a copy of the Bible in Gaelic in 1793, and it was decided to begin collecting Irish books and manuscripts, a sum of ten pounds being voted for this purpose. In this way originated the collection of manuscripts now housed in the Public Library in Belfast. Thomas Russell, the first secretary of the society, took Irish lessons from Patrick Lynch.

Dr James McDonnell eschewed politics, and although he earned the disfavour and even contempt of his more politically-minded friends for the pusillanimity he showed on at least two occasions, he never ceased to patronize Gaelic learning. As a medical man, McDonnell had ideas about resuscitation—he had been awarded the M.D. for a thesis on the subject at Edinburgh—and when Henry Joy McCracken had been cut down from the gallows his sister Mary sent an appeal to McDonnell to come to try to revive him. McDonnell did not come, but sent his brother, who did his best, in vain. Later, McDonnell was to contribute fifty guineas to the Government's reward fund for the capture of Thomas Russell, who was eventually hanged at Downpatrick for having attempted to stir up rebellion in the North as part of Emmet's projected rising. It was this action which drew from Drennan the biting lines:

> Let this man live and mind his trade
> But in unbounded space,
> Should he e'er chance on Russell's shade
> Oh, let him hide his face.

Nevertheless, when McDonnell died in 1845, Aodh Mac Domhnaill, the Gaelic poet whom he had employed as a scribe, composed a most effusive elegy for him, *Tuireadh an Dochtúir Mhic Dhomhnaill.*

Dr Samuel Neilson, a native of County Down, who was for some years professor of Hebrew in the Academical Institution, was the author of *An Introduction to the Irish Language,* which unjustly incurred the censure of O'Donovan, because of the 'barbaric' forms he thought he found in it. These were County Down forms, and the book is valuable to scholars for having preserved them. Neilson was arrested once on the suspicion of preaching sedition, because he had been preaching in Irish. The translation of his sermon showed that the suspicion was unfounded. *The Hibernian Magazine* for 13 July 1805 has it that 'on Thursday last, Dr Neilson preached a sermon in Irish in the Donegall street Meeting House in Belfast, to a numerous and respectable audience'.

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Robert McAdam, however, was undoubtedly the most indefatigable champion of the language in the North. He was a man of considerable means, being the owner of the Soho Iron Foundry in Townsend street, and hence he was able to engage scholars to assist him in his literary work. He sent Aodh MacDomhnaill, whom I have already mentioned, down to Donegal to collect songs, and there is a poem preserved in the Public Library in Belfast which is entitled 'A Poem of Reconciliation, composed for a married couple, called Andrew and Brigid of Glenties' who had entertained suspicions that McDonnell was a spy from Dublin Castle. This poem reminds one that Patrick Lynch in his day had been accused in Castlebar of being an emissary of the United Irishmen.

McAdam had more than the antiquary's interest in the language. He deplored the fact that it was being abandoned by the people all over the country. He gave three reasons for its decay: 'scholars who had no interest in the living language; writers using obscure language (not a novel complaint); the attitude of the Catholic Church, neglecting to teach Catechism and to give sermons in the language, although it was the language which had been the protecting shield of the Catholic faith for three hundred years, and the efforts of the Protestant Church to beguile the poor Catholics from their faith, the only result being that it had done more harm to the language than foreign persecution for three hundred years'.

PROVERBS

In the *Ulster Journal of Archaeology* of which he was editor, McAdam published some five hundred Gaelics proverbs which he had collected. These were to form the basis of Henry Morris's *Seanfhocla Uladh*. McAdam also compiled a dictionary, the manuscript of which has unfortunately disappeared. It was never printed.

A Gaelic society called *Cuideacht Gaeilge Uladh* was founded in Belfast in 1830 under the presidency of the Marquis of Down, with Dr Bryce, the headmaster of the Academical Institution, and McAdam as secretaries. The aims of the society were to gather manuscripts, to employ a teacher of the living language, and to publish useful books. Thomas Finnerty was engaged as a teacher, and it was he who translated one of Maria Edgeworth's tales under the title *Maith agus Dearmad*. In 1833 the Synod of the Presbyterian Church decided that some of the divinity students in the academy should learn Irish, and Finnerty was appointed to instruct them. Robert McAdam also taught there for a while, and he and Finnerty produced *An*

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Introduction to the Irish Classics in the Royal Belfast Academical Institution, Belfast. It would seem that Finnerty was also the author of a pamphlet published in 1835 entitled *Bolg an tSolair,* after the style of the supplement issued by the *Northern Star.*

There existed also in Belfast a ladies' Gaelic society, which published a primer in 1838.

Dr Samuel Bryson was interested mainly in the manuscript literature. He was a medical doctor who was attached to the Belfast Hospital, and assistant surgeon to the 32nd regiment. He was himself a diligent scribe. His brother Andrew who resided in Dundalk had been invited to the harpers' festival to translate the words of the Gaelic songs for Bunting, but did not attend. Dr Bryson is celebrated in the poem by Aodh Mac Domhnaill, entitled *Beirt Bhéal-Feirsteach,* published in *Dhá Chéad de Cheoltaibh Uladh.*

HENRY MONTGOMERY

The Reverend Henry Montgomery, the great remonstrant opponent of Cooke, had a deep appreciation of Irish culture. Two of his brothers had fought in the insurgent ranks at the battle of Antrim, his father's house had been burned by the soldiery in consequence, and Henry affirmed that he himself had suffered much loss on account of his patriotism, yet he remained an Irish nationalist in the broad, and perhaps best sense. He supported Catholic emancipation, speaking at a meeting of Catholics held in the new church of St Patrick in Donegall street, Belfast in 1829, which was presided over by Dr Crolly, the Bishop of Down and Connor. The reception of the Reverend Henry Montgomery when he stood out at the side of the bishop who occupied a seat at the foot of the altar is described as follows by the *Northern Whig*: 'The Reverend Henry Montgomery then advanced towards the altar, and was received with the most enthusiastic cheers, the immense multitude rising to their feet, with one simultaneous impulse.'

Montgomery rejected O'Connell's policy for the repeal of the Union, but his interest in the welfare of the Irish people and in their traditions was unfailing. In a dissertation entitled 'An Essay Investigating the Causes that have retarded literature in Ireland' read before the Belfast Rhetorical Society on November 25, 1840, he gave the proscription of the native language as one of the causes.

'Our peasantry', he declared, 'may be unlearned, but the most untutored of them all can hear a voice, speaking in the echoes of antiquity, which tells of the unforgotten greatness of their country. They learn a language from

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her venerable ruins which sends them back to the times and scenes of former splendour, and even in their cherished legends, wild and fanciful as they are, do they catch glimpses of glory, shrouded in the mist of past ages. And what are these but national history and poetry, unrecorded indeed, yet not forgotten, but doomed like unquiet spirits to wander up and down in the minds of people with undying wakefulness. And should not an effort be made to give these phantoms a material and palpable embodiment? Whatever be our particular differences on other subjects we can at least all unite our exertions and concentrate our energies in contributing to the exaltation of our common country.'

Montgomery published in Dublin in 1846 *Specimens of Early Native Poetry of Ireland in English Metrical Translation* by Miss Brooke, Dr Drummond, S. Ferguson, Mangan etc. with historical and biographical notices. I have not been able to ascertain whether he was intimate with the language or not.

A BLACK-MOUTHED PRESBYTERIAN

James McKnight, the leader of the tenant right movement in the North was an ardent student of Irish, and a lover of Irish literature and song. McKnight was born near Rathfriland in County Down, and it was there he learned Irish at his father's knee, for it was in the hill country around Rathfriland that Irish lingered longest in Down. In a letter to Gavan Duffy he says—'I am passionately fond of the old Irish melodies, and have long been picking them up wherever I could find them. Indeed, I was familiar with most of the airs in Moore before his melodies were heard of. My father had an enormous store of scraps of this kind, and when a child he used to sing them to me in Irish. You would hardly expect this from an old black-mouthed Presbyterian.'

When he lay on his deathbed in Derry, where he was editor of *The Londonderry Sentinel,* McKnight asked an old Catholic woman-servant to repeat the Lord's Prayer for him in Irish. This she did, and McKnight 'corrected' her pronunciation of one word, thus demonstrating that he was truly a Gaelic speaker and scholar to the last breath. The poor woman he 'corrected' was no doubt a good speaker of Irish from one of the surrounding counties, Donegal, Derry or Tyrone, in each of which the language was still strong, and her pronunciation of the particular word may have been slightly different from the County Down pronunciation, and consequently to McKnight's ear wrong. I am afraid that his servant was not the first, or last person, to be 'corrected' in that manner.

Of McKnight, Latimer the Presbyterian historian says 'He was a splen-

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did Keltic scholar, and had read everything dealing with the early history of his country.' He received the degree of Doctor of Laws from Aberdeen University, and read in addition to Irish and English, Latin, Greek, French and German. The writer has in his possession a copy of *Eagna Fhirinneach* an Irish translation of an Italian devotional work, which belonged to McKnight.

It is true that this interest shown by the Protestants of the North in Irish culture waned. O'Donovan was appointed as a professor of Celtic in the Queen's College that was set up in Belfast in 1849, but even O'Donovan did not attract any students. Strange as it may seem, however, popular extra-mural lectures which he gave on early Irish history, and folklore were well attended. The increasing indifference to the language and literature may be attributed to two causes, first to the utter failure of '98 which brought in its train a disillusionment with revolutionary ideas, and ultimately a rejection even of liberalism; secondly to the pressure of industrialization which changed Belfast from the pleasant enlightened town it had been into a mass of dark Satanic mills where there was little room for culture of any kind. The interest in Irish, however, did not wither completely. McAdam lived to see the first branch of the Gaelic League formed in Belfast in 1895. Many Protestants joined the League in its early days. A granddaughter of Dr James McDonnell, Miss Barbara McDonnell, presided over the first Glens feis, held in Glenariff, the home of the McDonnells, in 1904. The Gaelic Society of Queen's University was founded by a young Belfast Protestant, William MacArthur, in 1906, who was to become famous in our time as Sir William MacArthur, K.C.B., D.S.O., O.B.E., M.D. etc., and who never lost his love for the language. A few years ago he presented a valuable silver trophy for competition in drama among the Gaelic-speaking school children of Donegal. Unfortunately, the acceleration of the Home Rule movement caused many Protestants to turn away from the revival of the language, for they feared involvement in the political struggle.

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